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BLOOD

On 28 July 2010, Major General Campbell, a US commander in Afghanistan, said that ‘anytime there’s any sort of leak of classified material, it has the potential to harm the military folks that are working out here every day’. Major Campbell also admitted that he had not read any of the leaked documents. The following day, at a Pentagon press conference, Defense Secretary Robert M. Gates and Admiral Mike Mullen ramped up this strategic piece of mythmaking. ‘Mr Assange can say whatever he likes about the greater good he thinks he and his source are doing,’ said Mullen, ‘but the truth is they might already have on their hands the blood of some young soldier or that of an Afghan family.’

A member of the press corps asked a question.

> *Journalist*: Admiral Mullen, you have mentioned that the founder of WikiLeaks may have blood on his hands. Do you know, have people been killed over this information?

> *Mullen*: They’re still . . . what I’m concerned about with this is I think individuals who are not involved in this kind of warfare and expose this kind of information can’t . . . from my perspective . . . can’t appreciate how this kind of information is routinely networked together inside the classified channels we use specifically. And it’s very difficult, if you don’t do this and understand this, to understand the impact, and very specifically the potential that is there . . . that is there to risk lives of our soldiers and sailors, airmen and Marines, coalition warfighters, as well . . . as well as Afghan citizens. And there’s no doubt in my mind about that.